



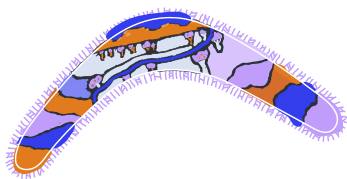
sva | consulting

A large, thick, curved swoosh that starts from the left edge, curves downwards and to the right, and then curves back up and to the left, ending near the bottom right. The top portion of the swoosh is orange, and the bottom portion is a light purple color.

Migrant Workers Centre (MWC) SROI Report

**Social Return on Investment (SROI)
Evaluation Report**

Prepared for: Migrant Workers Centre (MWC)
Date: 18 September 2024



Acknowledgment of Country

Social Ventures Australia acknowledges and pays respect to the past and present traditional custodians and elders of this country on which we work.

'After the Rains' by Richard Seden for Saltwater People 2024

Project acknowledgements

Social Ventures Australia (SVA) would like to acknowledge the participation of migrant workers and MWC's staff and partner organisations, who took time to share their stories and expertise, contributing to the strong evidence base that is critical to this evaluation.

Legal disclosure statement

SVA has prepared this report in good faith on the basis of the research and information available to SVA at the date of publication.

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This report has been prepared by SVA Consulting

SVA is a not-for-profit organisation that works with partners to alleviate disadvantage – towards an Australia where all people and communities thrive.

We influence systems to deliver better social outcomes for people by learning about what works in communities, helping organisations be more effective, sharing our perspectives and advocating for change.

SVA Consulting is Australia's leading not-for-profit consultancy. We focus solely on social impact and work with partners to increase their capacity to create positive change. Thanks to more than 15 years of working with not-for-profits, government and funders, we have developed a deep understanding of the sector and 'what works'.

Our team is passionate about what they do and use their diverse experience to work together to solve Australia's most pressing challenges.

This report has been authored by SVA Consulting by Emily Low, Jonathan Finighan and Simon Faivel.

For more information contact us:

consulting@socialventures.org.au

About this report

Migrant Workers Centre (MWC) commissioned SVA to undertake a Social Return on Investment (SROI) evaluation of its work with migrant workers and communities to determine the socio-economic returns of its support.

This is the first time that SVA has conducted a SROI evaluation for MWC. The evaluation's approach is guided by the Principles of Social Value (Source: [The Principles of Social Value](#), Social Value International, accessed September 2023):

1. Involve stakeholders
2. Understand what changes
3. Value the things that matter
4. Only include what is material
5. Do not overclaim
6. Be transparent
7. Verify the result
8. Be responsive

The focus of the evaluation is MWC's impact on migrant workers and communities. Although MWC also creates value for migrant workers' families, partner organisations, and the Australian and Victorian governments – the decision was made to focus on MWC's impact on its primary stakeholders in this first report.

This report tells the story about the value of the changes created by MWC, relative to the investment. The SROI ratio is a shorthand for this story.

Evaluation scope

The evaluation values MWC's work from July 2021 to April 2024 (inclusive). Organisational data, interviews, and external research were used to inform the approach and validate assumptions. Quotes from interviews are included throughout the report. See the appendix for detail on the SROI evaluation approach.



Summary of findings

Key activities

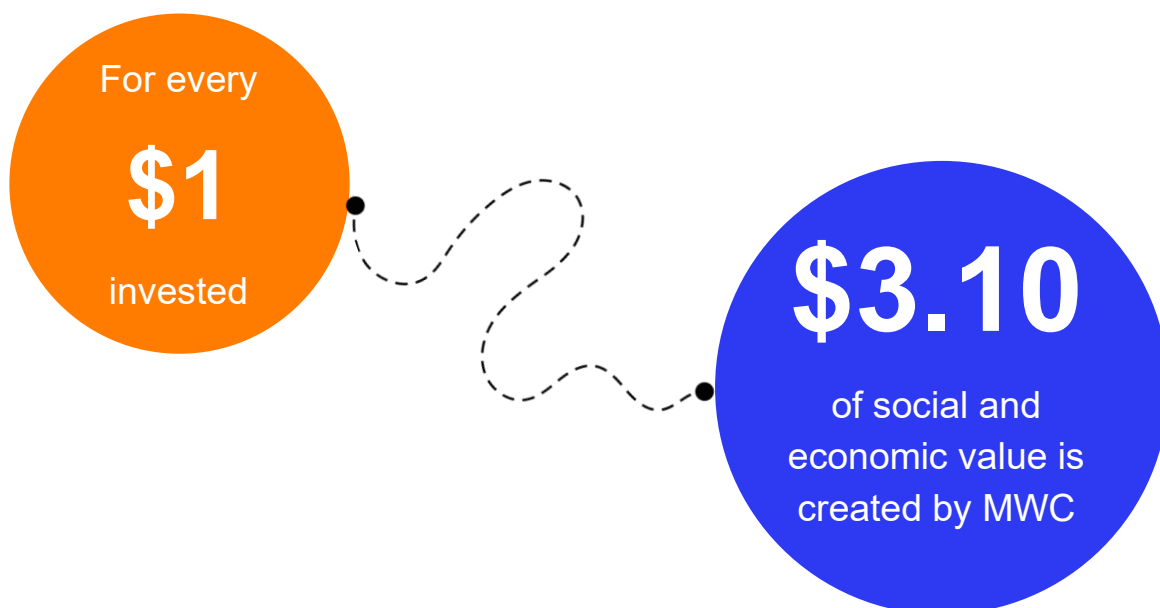
From July 2021 to April 2024, MWC's key activities included:

- Supporting individual migrant workers on 640 workplace justice cases
- Educating 7,633 participants about their work rights at community education sessions
- Raising awareness about work rights and support available at outreach events attended by 5,192 people
- Elevating the voices and priorities of migrant workers and communities in 5 research and advocacy campaigns

Social Return on Investment (SROI)

The evaluation led to an SROI ratio, which illustrates the social and economic benefits that are being created by MWC.

From July 2021 to April 2024, ~\$3.9m was invested in operating MWC delivering an estimated ~\$11.9m in social and economic benefits. This equates to an SROI ratio of 3.1: 1.



The SROI ratio is conservative because the value created by MWC's research and advocacy work is not included while the total investment in MWC is. Comparing the investment in MWC's casework and community education to the value that they created equates to an SROI ratio of 3.9: 1.

Insights

This report identifies five key insights about MWC's impact.

1

MWC plays a unique role in the services system – MWC are the only organisation in Australia who provide casework support, community education, and carry out research and advocacy with a specific focus on migrant workers' rights.

2

Language is critical – MWC's commitment to providing support in in the preferred languages of migrant workers and communities (over 50 languages throughout the evaluation period) increases their accessibility and quality of support.

3

MWC's casework fills a significant gap in existing supports – MWC's casework responds to significant unmet demand for free and accessible support to navigate underpayment, injury, bullying and termination issues among migrant workers.

4

MWC is committed to collective action – MWC elevates what they learn supporting individual migrant workers and communities to contribute to systemic change, in strong partnership with organisations who bring complementary skills and relationships.

5

MWC's team bring lived experience and community connections to their work – MWC's team are members of the communities that they work alongside to support, bringing strong knowledge about what changes are needed and the best ways to achieve it.



Impact snapshot: Migrant workers

The evaluation uncovered a range of outcomes for individual migrant workers supported through casework. Casework support was provided in 58 different languages.

Individuals experienced the following changes:

Increased understanding of rights and support available



\$2,600,000

536 migrant workers learned about their rights and supports available through MWC, enabling them to advocate for their rights with employers. The support provided ranged from general information and advice, to working alongside migrant workers to support them to self-represent in negotiations with their employers.

Improved mental health



\$830,000

364 migrant workers are estimated to have experienced improved mental health because of the MWC's support. Approximately 60% of migrant workers reported that the MWC's support made them less stressed during a time of uncertainty and vulnerability.

Individuals experienced the following economic outcomes, based on MWC's casework data:

Recovery of unpaid entitlements: wages or benefits



\$810,000

84 migrant workers successfully claimed unpaid wages or benefits. The average amount recovered was \$12,200, with individual amounts ranging from \$300 to \$115,000.

Recovery of unpaid entitlements: injury compensation



\$220,000

20 migrant workers successfully claimed injury compensation through the WorkCover system. The average amount recovered was \$14,300, with individual amounts ranging from \$500 to \$56,000.

Impact snapshot: Migrant communities

The evaluation uncovered the following key outcome experienced by migrant communities, due to community members attending free community education sessions.

Increased understanding of rights and support available



\$8,180,000

7,633 members of migrant communities were supported to learn about their rights and support available by attending free community education sessions. This includes 7,474 attendees at MWC's Know Your Rights sessions and 159 attendees at Work Rights Clinics. Many of these sessions were facilitated by the 37 Ambassadors trained as part of MWC's Bicultural Work Rights Ambassadors Program.

This is the same outcome experienced by individual migrant workers supported through casework. The increase in understanding is relatively less for community members attending community education sessions than individuals supported through casework, reflecting the different depths of support provided.



Impact snapshot: Research and advocacy

The evaluation highlighted the contributions that MWC made through its research and advocacy work, as part of a wider collective of communities, organisations, and individuals working to create change.

Targeted research and advocacy work



MWC led 5 research and advocacy campaigns, made 11 policy submissions, and held 2 conferences attended by 527 people. This work contributed to raising awareness and support for equal opportunities and protections for migrant workers among governments and the Australian public.

Workplace Justice Visa



MWC played a key role in the development and approval of the new Workplace Justice Visa during the evaluation period, which came into effect in July 2024. The visa allows migrant workers on temporary visas who have faced workplace exploitation to remain in Australia for 6 to 12 months to pursue workplace justice activities.

The problem

Many migrant workers in Australia have experiences where their workplace rights are violated or not recognised.

Some workers are not aware of their rights due to language and cultural barriers. Others do not want to jeopardise their employment or visa that has an uncertain future. Recent migrants are 40% more likely to be underpaid compared to long-term residents with similar skills doing the same job (Source: Short-changed: How to stop the exploitation of migrant workers in Australia, Grattan Institute, May 2023).

“I didn’t know what my rights were.” – Worker supported by MWC

The scale of this problem is big, with hundreds of thousands of migrant workers arriving in Australia every year.

Migrant workers bring skills and experience and make strong contributions to local communities and the economy. Most migrant workers who arrive hold temporary visas, which can increase their vulnerability to exploitation.

Year ending	Number of migrant workers arriving	Number of migrant workers arriving on temporary visas
June 2022	426,730	266,210
June 2023	737,170	553,540

Source: Overseas migration (2022-23 financial year), Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS), released 15/12/2023

There is limited awareness of workplace rights and where to get support within migrant communities.

Many people are not aware of their workplace rights in Australia and how they might be different to countries they have worked in previously. Some employers also lack knowledge and may be unaware when they are violating an employees' rights.

*"We don't have lots of knowledge about rights in Australia."
– Worker supported by MWC*

Workplace rights violations continue due to an unjust system.

While government policy and legislation are meant to protect the rights of all workers, in practice there are many instances where policy and legislation exacerbates the challenges faced by migrant workers. Furthermore, institutions and regulatory bodies established to support migrant workers' rights are often not accessible to the workers themselves.

"The only other agency we were aware of was Fair Work, but we didn't know how to contact them." – Worker supported by MWC



About MWC

MWC empowers migrant workers in Victoria to understand their rights, enforce them in workplaces, and connect with other migrant workers. It carries out the following key activities:

1. **Casework.** Providing tailored and individual support to migrant workers with a workplace issue.
2. **Community education.** Providing information and raising awareness about migrant workers' rights through the following four community education programs:
 - Know Your Rights sessions
 - Work Rights Clinic
 - Ambassadors program
 - Outreach
3. **Research and advocacy.** Developing reports and running campaigns to promote changes in attitudes, policy, and legislation to support migrant workers and communities.

Across these activities, the MWC provides support in more than 50 languages, travelling to the places preferred by migrant workers and communities.



MWC's approach

Community led

Migrant communities shape MWC's focus, how support is provided, and what MWC advocates for. MWC elevates the voices of the migrant workers and communities that they work with and represent.

Empowering

MWC works directly with migrant workers and communities to educate, support, and empower them to resolve their workplace issues, so they can ultimately do so without MWC's support.

Responsive

MWC is committed to delivering support in the languages and places of the individuals and communities that they work with, tailored to their specific needs.

Collaborative

MWC work in close partnership with community services organisations, unions, and academics and researchers to create change as a collective. They recognise the expertise that they bring and the complementary expertise of their partners.



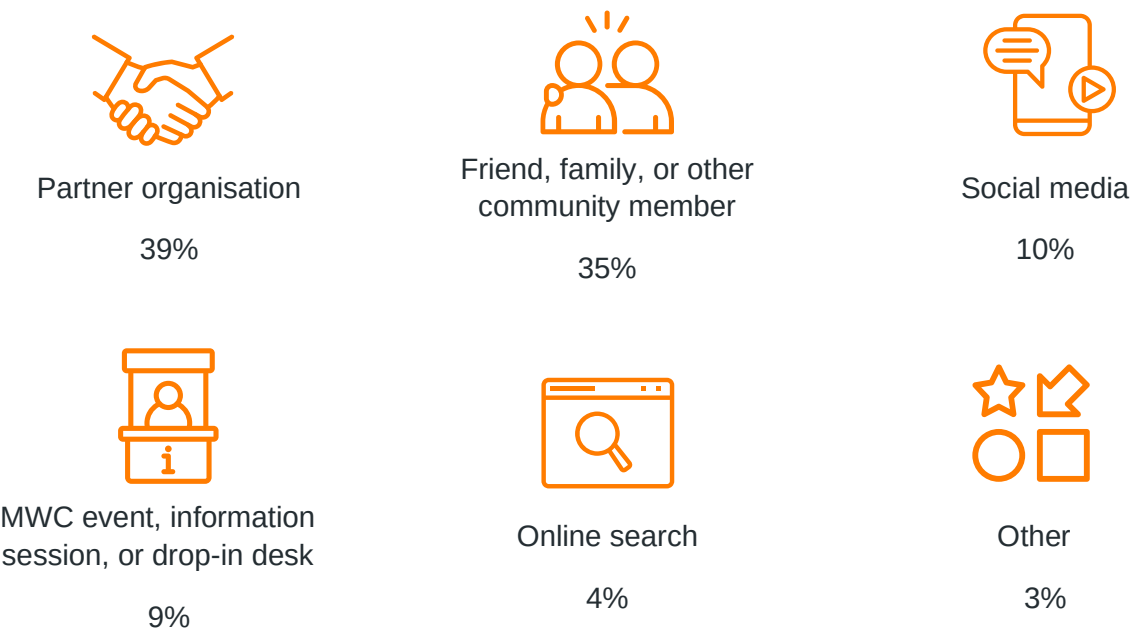
MWC's activities

This section further describes MWC's three core activities: casework support, community education and research and advocacy.

Activity 1: Casework support

Referral

During the evaluation period, individual migrant workers supported through casework were referred to MWC in the following ways.



Level of support provided

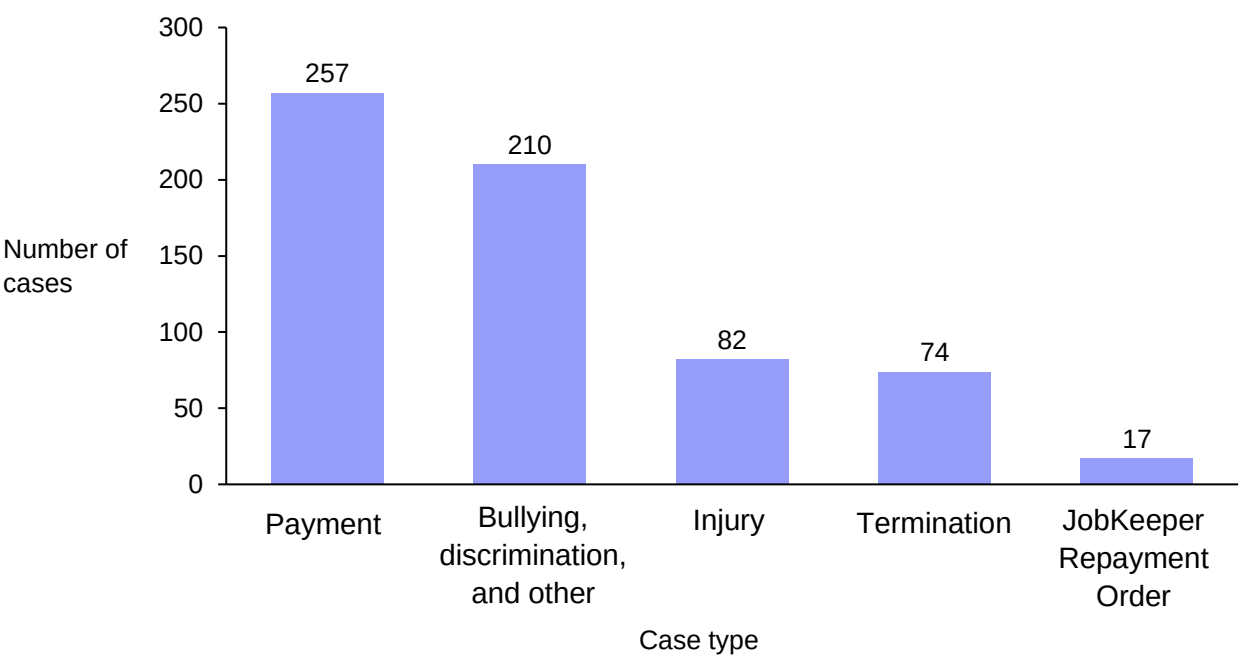
MWC provided individual migrant workers with different levels of support, depending on the needs and guidance of the individual.

Activities included:

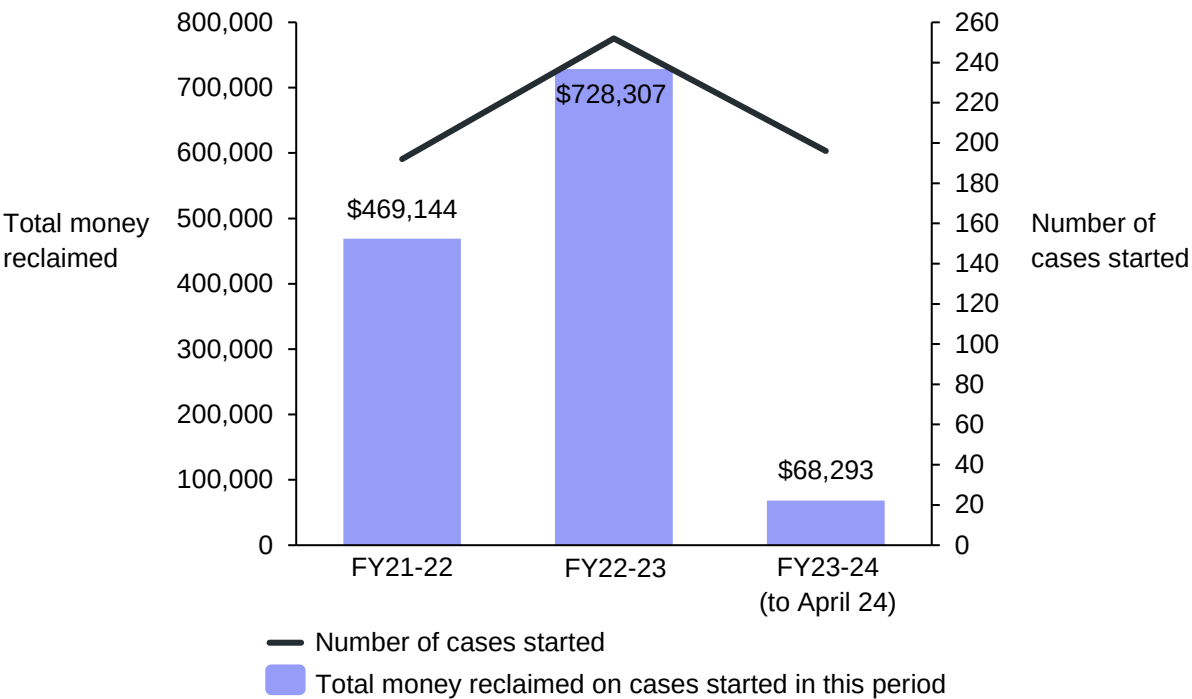
- In-person or phone conversations to understand the situation, explore options, and support the individual to carry out their desired course of action
- Document collection and assessment to provide tailored information
- Underpayment calculations
- Letters of demand and injury claim forms
- 46% of individual migrant workers were supported in a language other than English
- Casework support was provided in 58 different languages.

Types of support provided

MWC supported 640 cases over the evaluation period with a variety of workplace justice issues. The most common issue faced by workers receiving casework support was related to underpayment or unfair payment, followed by bullying, discrimination and related issues.



In the first two years of the evaluation period, MWC supported many individuals to claim unpaid entitlements from employers, including wages, benefits, and injury compensation. MWC stopped providing this support in FY23-24, to focus their resources on formally registering as a Community Legal Centre. They plan to start providing this support again once they are registered.



After receiving casework support

In general, individuals who received casework support believe that MWC's support was relevant and empowering. The following proportions of individual migrant workers supported through casework agreed or strongly agreed with the following statements in a MWC led survey conducted in April to May 2023.

- 89%** Staff listened to your workplace problem and helped you feel welcome and safe.
- 87%** The information was relevant to you.
- 87%** The information helped you to understand your rights and responsibilities.
- 85%** Staff helped you understand how to deal with your workplace issue.
- 83%** The information was clear and easy to understand.
- 83%** You have a better understanding of your workplace issues.
- 81%** You feel more confident to get help about a workplace issue in the future.
- 52%** You feel more confident to handle your own workplace issues in the future, without getting help from a service like ours.

The impact of MWC's casework support was validated through interviews with migrant workers supported by MWC. Migrant workers consistently said that they did not know where else they could have got this support.

"I would not have been able to fix the problem without MWC. They told me about my rights, guided me to follow instructions, and helped me to fill the forms."
– Worker supported by MWC

Activity 2: Community education

MWC provided community education through four key activities, to maximise their reach and accessibility to migrant communities.

Know Your Rights sessions

Know Your Rights sessions focus on basic workplace rights and safety. Sessions were free and delivered in a range of languages. MWC were connected to community members through education institutions, community services organisations, and community groups.

Number of sessions: 328

“The MWC’s Know Your Rights Sessions are unique because they are really focussed on employment rights for migrants. Their mobile service delivery is also unique. I don’t know of any other organisations providing similar support.” – Partner organisation

Work Rights Clinics

Work Rights Clinics give migrant workers the opportunity to receive an initial 1-on-1 consultation with MWC staff about a workplace question or issue. Clinics were often delivered following Know Your Rights sessions.

Number of sessions: 36

Number of participants: 159

Outreach

MWC conducted outreach by attending university and TAFE open days, employer events, union events, and community meet-ups. This increased the visibility of MWC to migrant workers and communities, so that more people knew where to get support if they or someone in their community or workplace needed it.

Number of events: 68

Number of attendees: 5,192

"MWC attend events that we host for international students across Melbourne... then students share information between themselves about MWC." – Partner organisation

Bicultural Work Rights Ambassadors Program

The Bicultural Work Rights Ambassadors Program trains and empowers community leaders to deliver sessions about workplace rights and safety to their community members. Ambassadors were supported to deliver sessions in their own language and communities, enabling MWC to reach more people across Victoria.

Number of Ambassadors trained: 37

"The Ambassadors program helps people who have potential to be leaders to have confidence to speak in front of a crowd, in English or other languages.

My favourite session was with the Adult Migrant English School in Melbourne. It was a picnic, there was a huge crowd, and it happened very spontaneously. We shared and exchanged different experiences. This group didn't know about MWC before but now they refer people."

– Ambassador

In a survey of Ambassadors conducted by MWC from March to December 2023, the following proportions of Ambassadors reported that they value the following elements of the Ambassador role.

91% Empowering their communities

78% Learning about workers' rights

74% Being able to do meaningful work in an area they care about

74% Seeing positive outcomes in their community as a result of their work



Activity 3: Research and advocacy

Research and advocacy are a key part of the MWC's work. They allow MWC to contribute to systemic change affecting all migrant workers in Australia, in addition to supporting specific individuals and communities through casework and community education.

MWC's research and advocacy work is driven by the voices and lived experience of migrant workers. Interviews with partner organisations and MWC staff highlighted this as a defining feature of MWC's approach.

"MWC's research has strong value in articulating the experiences and concerns of migrant workers. They constitute and give voice to communities, taking a long-term approach." – Partner organisation

MWC collaborates with a broad group of communities, organisations, and individuals working to create change. They are recognised for their connections to migrant communities and governments.

MWC is also uniquely connected to the union movement: although MWC is not a union, it emerged out of the union movement and work closely with unions to advocate for migrant workers' rights. Consultations showed that partner organisations and staff recognise the importance of having support available for migrant workers outside of unions, given mixed attitudes and low union membership among migrant workers. However, the value of MWC working in partnership with unions was also recognised, because they can draw on each other's expertise and relationships to advocate for migrant workers' rights together.

"MWC's dual knowledge of workplace rights and unions is very unique. It is very powerful when complemented by the ability to communicate in different languages." – Partner organisation

MWC delivered the following research and advocacy outputs during the evaluation period.



**5 research and
advocacy
campaigns**



**11 policy
submissions**



**2 conferences
attended by
527 people**

Workplace Justice Visa

The Workplace Justice Visa allows migrant workers on temporary visas who have faced workplace exploitation to remain in Australia for 6 to 12 months, to pursue workplace justice activities. They can work while they stay, and family members are also able to apply for the visa. The Workplace Justice Visa came into effect in July 2024 (Source: [Migration Amendment \(Workplace Justice Visa\) Regulations 2024](#)), Federal Register of Legislation, 29 June 2024).

In interviews with partner organisations, MWC was recognised as playing a central role in the development and approval of the Workplace Justice Visa, including participating in the co-design process for the initial pilot of the visa. MWC were part of a wider collective of key advocates for the legislative change, including the Human Rights Law Centre and Migrant Justice Institute.

“The Workplace Justice Visa wouldn’t have happened without MWC.”
– Partner organisation

MWC has also been approved by the Australian Government to issue certificates that are required by individuals to apply for the Workplace Justice Visa, which confirm that they need to be present in Australia to address a workplace justice matter. MWC is one of just 18 organisations approved nationally.

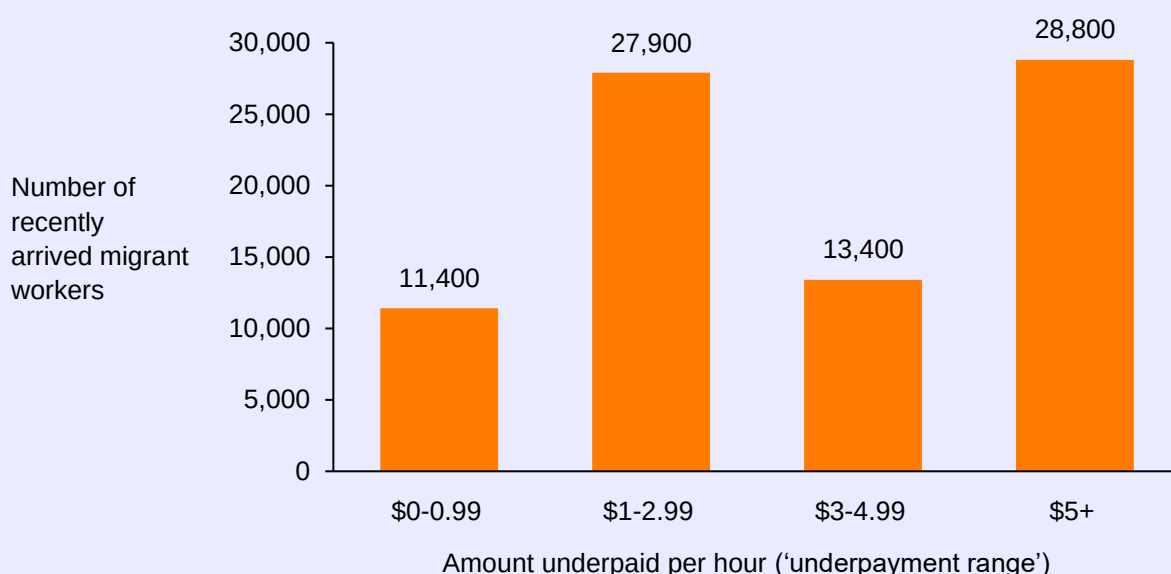
MWC dedicated considerable time and expertise to the development and approval of the Workplace Justice Visa during the evaluation period. However, because the visa did not come into effect until July 2024 (after the evaluation period), this outcome has not been valued in the SROI.

On the next page, a high-level estimate of the potential value that the Workplace Justice Visa will bring to migrant workers paid less than the minimum wage is summarised. Note that this estimate should be interpreted as indicative only as it is based on 2022 data and publicly available analysis of ABS datasets, rather than the source datasets themselves.

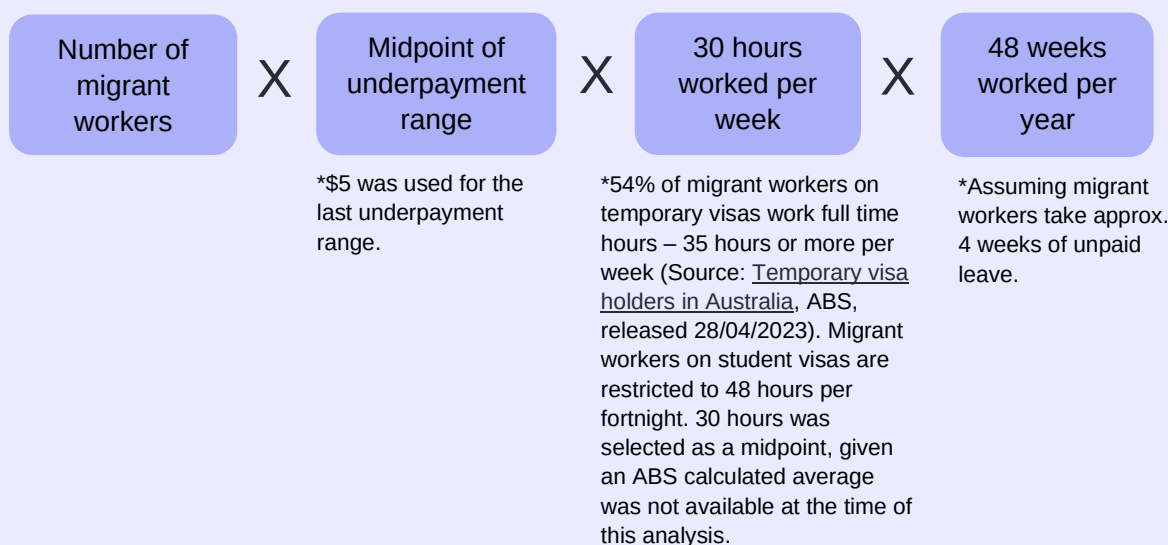


Potential value of the Workplace Justice Visa for migrant workers paid less than the minimum wage (2022 data)

1. In 2022, it is estimated that up to 82,000 recently arrived migrant workers (who arrived in Australia in the last five years) were paid less than the minimum wage (Source: [Short-changed: How to stop the exploitation of migrant workers in Australia](#), Grattan Institute, May 2023).
2. The graph below shows the number of migrant workers underpaid by different amounts (using data from the source above).



3. The total amount that recently arrived migrants were underpaid in 2022 can be estimated by multiplying the following for each underpayment range above and adding the results together.



4. The estimated total amount that recently arrived migrants were underpaid in 2022 indicates the potential value of the Workplace Justice Visa for recently arrived migrant workers paid less than the minimum wage.

~\$373m total

~\$4,600 per migrant worker

~6 weeks of full-time work per migrant worker

This is because it is money that could potentially be recovered by migrant workers enabled to stay in Australia by the visa while they pursue their underpayment claims.

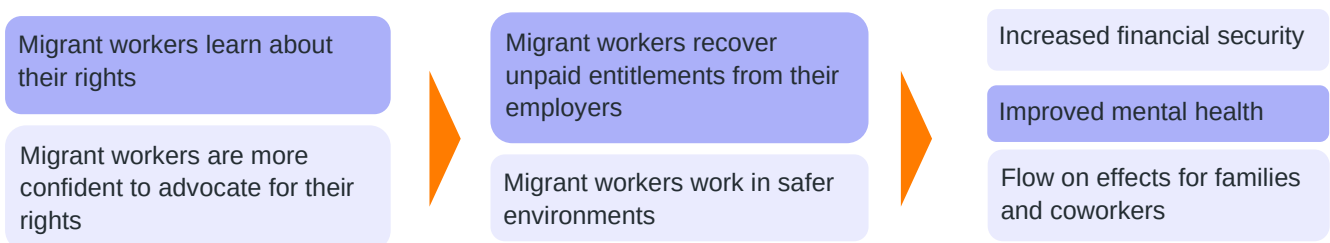
Underpayment below the minimum wage is just one type of workplace issue that the Workplace Justice Visa will enable migrant workers to stay in Australia and address. Regardless, it highlights the massive potential value of the Workplace Justice Visa to future migrant workers, and the value of MWC's work in partnership with other organisations and migrant communities to advocate for this legislative change during the evaluation period.



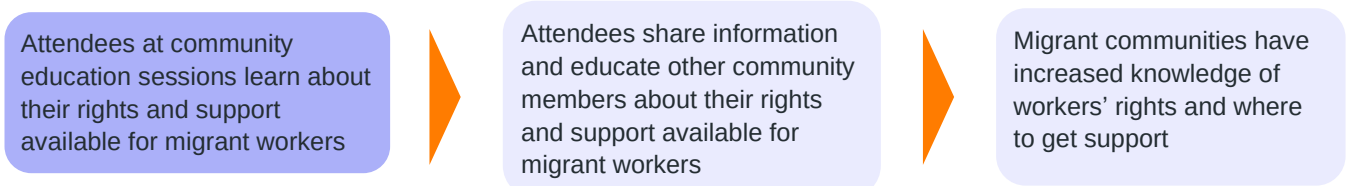
Outcomes created by MWC

This section presents evidence on the outcomes created by MWC through its activities, focusing on the outcomes that were considered material for the SROI analysis. The evaluation found that MWC creates a wide range of outcomes for different stakeholder groups: individual migrant workers, migrant communities, governments and unions. For the purposes of the SROI analysis and deciding which should be included in the valuation, only some of these were determined to be material. These are identified in the diagram below and described further on the following pages.

Individual migrant workers supported through casework



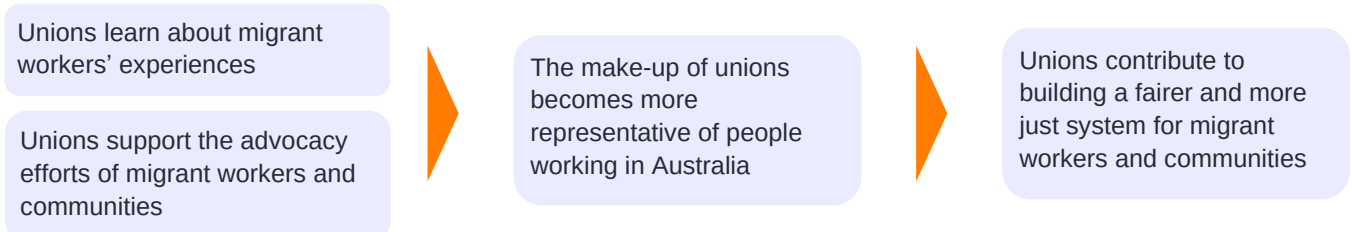
Migrant communities supported through community education sessions



Governments engaged through research and advocacy

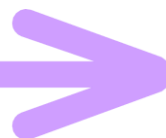


Unions engaged as partners



Legend

Outcome measured and valued in SROI



Outcomes for migrant workers supported through casework

\$2.6m

Increased understanding of rights and support available

Through one-on-one casework, 536 individuals were supported to increase their understanding about their rights and support available. This outcome was valued at \$2,600,000 over 5 years as the outcome lasts for a long time after the intervention.

During the evaluation period, MWC provided casework support to individuals navigating workplace issues relating to payment, bullying, discrimination, termination, and injury. This outcome was valued for individuals supported through casework who did not recover unpaid entitlements such as wages or injury compensation. It is important to note that this does not necessarily mean that the support was 'unsuccessful'. It could be due to:

- Individuals seeking support for matters unrelated to claiming unpaid entitlements
- MWC not being aware of the outcome of a claim, which often happens when the claim takes a long period of time to be recognised
- Individuals being supported through part of the process but ultimately deciding not to make a claim

This outcome was not valued for individuals who did recover unpaid entitlements to avoid 'double counting' MWC's impact (see the next page).

MWC worked alongside individuals to understand the situation, their rights, and potential courses of action. They provided casework support in the preferred language of the individual being supported, with 46% of migrant workers receiving support in a language other than English. Support was provided in 58 different languages across the evaluation period.

In a survey conducted in April to May 2023, 87% of migrant workers supported through casework reported that the information provided helped them to understand their rights and responsibilities. 52% reported that they felt safer at work following the MWC's support. Interviews with migrant workers highlighted that their increased understanding of rights continued beyond the time when they were receiving support. Many individuals went on to share their knowledge about rights and support available with family and community members.

"I don't have any experience on these kinds of things. My friends and colleagues haven't experienced it. MWC are most helpful to people who don't know anything." – Worker supported by MWC

Improved mental health

As a result of one-on-one casework, 364 migrant workers are estimated to have experienced improved mental health. This outcome was valued at \$830,000 over the evaluation period.

Approximately 60% of migrant workers reported that the MWC's support made them less stressed during a time of uncertainty and vulnerability. Many migrant workers experience isolation and loneliness, which can be exacerbated when they experience workplace issues. Having the MWC's support made individuals' challenges a shared problem and provided assurance that there was a way forward.

Interviews suggested that improved mental health is a flow on effect of MWC's support, rather than the direct result of activities designed to create this outcome. Mental health support for migrant workers and communities was identified as a key gap in the service system. Some migrant workers and partner organisations suggested that MWC could contribute to filling this gap by providing wraparound support to the migrant workers they support through casework. They could consider employing mental health specialists directly or partnering with other organisations who already have this expertise.

"We are in the dark and they help us to find light. That time was very dark, I was struggling. The Migrant Workers Centre helped me – I am super satisfied." – Worker supported by MWC



\$0.8m

Recovery of unpaid entitlements: wages or benefits

Through one-on-one casework, 84 migrant workers were supported to successfully claim unpaid wages or benefits. The average amount recovered was \$12,200, with individual amounts ranging from \$300 to \$115,000. This outcome was valued at \$810,000 over the evaluation period.

13% of individual migrant workers supported through casework successfully claimed unpaid wages or benefits. MWC supported these workers to understand their situation, rights and options as well as carry out underpayment calculations when necessary. In consultation, migrant workers shared feeling overwhelmed and directionless before getting support from MWC. They expressed gratitude for MWC supporting them to navigate the process.

The flow on effects from recovering unpaid entitlements varied depending on the amount recovered. Twenty individuals were supported to recover more than \$20,000, with significant potential to impact their financial security and families. The average amount reclaimed by the other 64 individuals was still significant at \$4,800 – more than 5 weeks of full-time work at minimum wage.

Approximately one quarter of these cases were referred to another organisation, including law firms and community legal centres, to help make the claim.

“The payment helped between the time when I lost my old job and got a new one. My family were able to live a fairly similar life.”
 – Worker supported to claim ~\$80,000

\$0.2m

Recovery of unpaid entitlements: injury compensation

Through one-on-one casework, 20 migrant workers were supported to successfully claim injury compensation or navigate the WorkCover system. The average amount recovered was \$14,300, with individual amounts ranging from \$500 to \$56,000. This outcome was valued at \$220,000 over the evaluation period.

In consultation, migrant workers who were injured at work shared stories about a lack of direction from employers on where to get help and challenges navigating the WorkCover system. MWC supported these workers to understand their situation, rights, and options, fill out injury claim forms, and communicate with employers. This enabled migrant workers to receive compensation for medical expenses, weekly payments while unable to work, and superannuation payments.

As above, approximately one quarter of these cases were referred to another organisation, including Union Assist, who specialise in supporting injured union workers with information and support services. Union Assist's partnership with MWC is special because migrant workers referred through MWC do not need to be a union member to receive Union Assist's support, breaking down potential barriers to access.

“Without the Centre and the advice that they gave me during the accident, I wouldn't know what to do. This is what is so special, they guided me to my rights.” – Worker supported to make injury compensation claim



Outcomes for migrant communities

\$8.2m

Increased understanding of rights and support available

By attending free community education sessions, 7,633 members of migrant communities were supported to learn about their work rights and support available. This outcome was valued at \$8,180,000 over 5 years as the outcome lasts for a long time after the intervention.

This includes 7,474 attendees at MWC's Know Your Rights sessions and 159 attendees at Work Rights Clinics. Many of these sessions were facilitated by the 37 Ambassadors trained as part of MWC's Bicultural Work Rights Ambassadors Program.

Community education sessions were delivered in the languages and places preferred by partner organisations or participants. Consultation with partner organisations highlighted MWC's expertise, flexibility in scheduling sessions, and responsiveness to the specific needs of the group participating. They reported strong engagement at the sessions due to them being delivered in the first language of attendees and use of stories and examples.

Some partner organisations reported seeing attendees go on to share information and educate other community members about their rights and support available for migrant workers, allowing the impact of the sessions to spread further within the community.

"The knowledge that our clients receive is very beneficial. They have the basic information they need to know when something is wrong. They know that they can get advice from MWC and sometimes reach out down the track." – Partner organisation



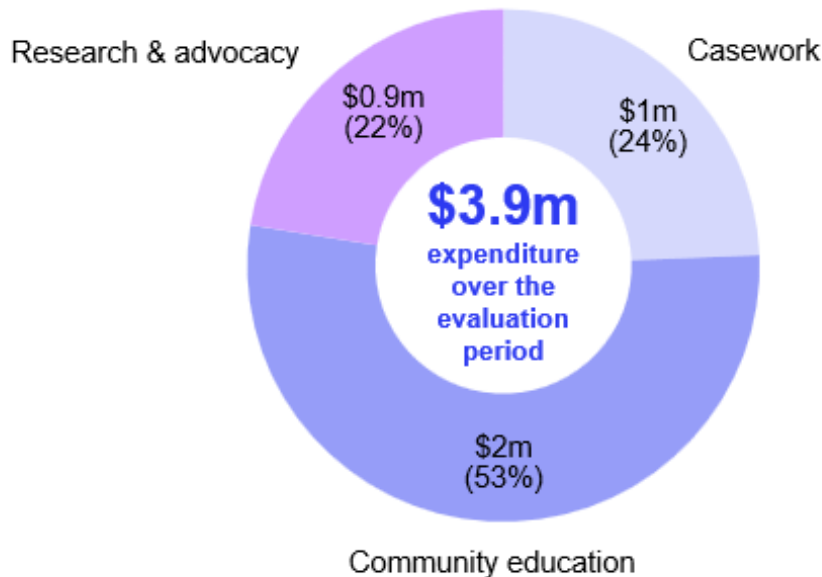
Calculating the SROI ratio

Investment

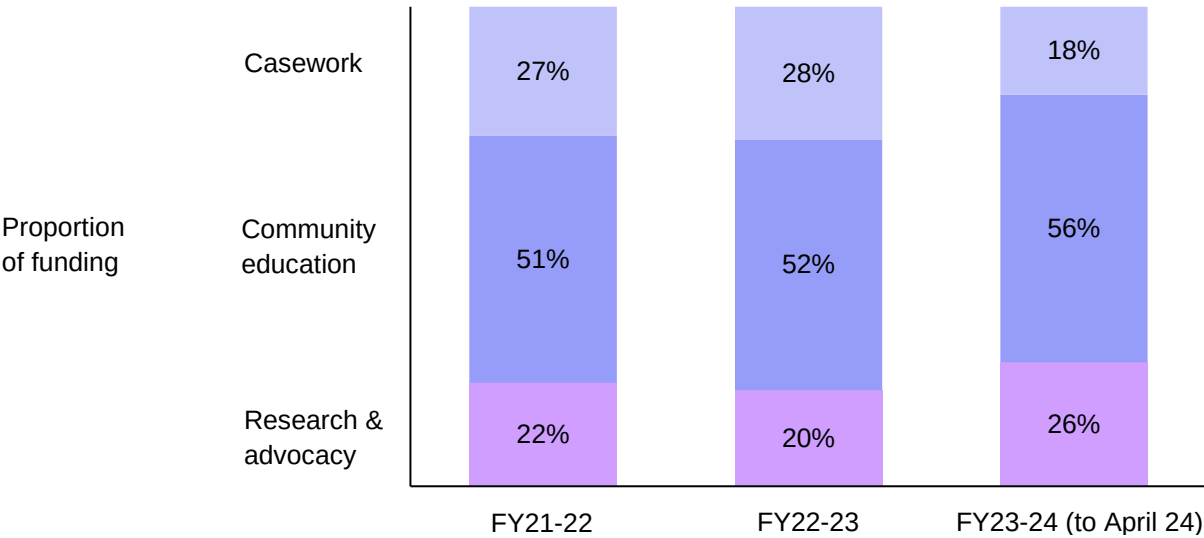
Total investment in MWC from July 2021 to April 2024 was ~\$3.9m. This represents the total value of monetary (cash) contributions that were required to achieve the outcomes that are measured and valued in the SROI analysis. MWC received no material in-kind contributions in the evaluation period.

MWC is fully funded by the Victorian Government. It receives funding through a single contract, working closely with the Multicultural Affairs Team within the Department of Premier and Cabinet to align their activities to community needs. MWC's work contributes to the Victorian Government's commitment to supporting diverse communities as outlined in the Government's Multicultural Affairs Outcomes Framework (Source: [Multicultural policy statement: Multicultural Affairs Outcomes Framework](#), Victorian Government, 2021).

MWC's expenditure over the evaluation period can be viewed across its casework, community education, and research and advocacy work.



The proportion of funding spent on casework decreased in FY23-24, as MWC focussed their resources on formally registering as a Community Legal Centre.



All investment is considered in the SROI calculation because MWC’s casework, community education, and research and advocacy work reinforce one another. For example, the workplace issues that individuals sought casework support on informed community education topics. Community education sessions led to greater take up of casework support. MWC’s different types of work are all critical to its impact.

“The MWC is unique because they are an overarching umbrella to cover all issues that migrant workers may have... They are growing day by day and it is so important that they are around.” – Partner organisation



Outcomes

The total value of material outcomes generated by MWC over this period is **\$11.9m** in total present value terms.¹ This includes **\$1.0m** in cash to individual migrant workers supported to recover unpaid entitlements through casework. The table below presents the total estimated value generated for each outcome.

Outcome	Value (rounded)	Share of total value for stakeholder	Total value by stakeholder (rounded)	Share of total value
Individual migrant workers supported through casework				
Increased understanding of rights and support available	\$2,600,000	58%	\$4,450,000	35%
Improved mental health	\$830,000	19%		
Recovery of unpaid entitlements: wages or benefits	\$810,000	18%		
Recovery of unpaid entitlements: injury compensation	\$220,000	5%		
Migrant communities				
Increased understanding of rights and support available	\$8,180,000	100%	\$8,180,000	65%
Total	\$12,630,000			
Total present value (including discount rate 2.5%)	\$11,930,000			
Total investment	\$3,900,000			
SROI ratio	3.1			

¹ A discount rate of 2.5% p.a. was applied to the total value of investments and outcomes to calculate present value. This captures the time value of money and allows us to compare like-for-like investments and outcomes. This rate was chosen as it is the midpoint of the 2-3% range that the Reserve Bank of Australia aims to keep consumer price inflation between, on average, over time.

SROI ratio

3.1 : 1

Based on the investment and operations from July 2021 to April 2024, MWC generated an SROI of 3.1 : 1.



SROI ratio
3.1 : 1



Present value of benefits
\$11.9m

Present value of investment
\$3.9m

That is, for every \$1 invested in MWC, \$3.10 of social and economic value is created.

Notes:

- The SROI ratio is conservative because the value created by MWC's research and advocacy work is not included while the total investment in MWC is. Comparing the investment in MWC's casework and community education to the value that they created equates to an SROI ratio of 3.9: 1. See *Activity 3: Research and advocacy* for a discussion of the impact of MWC's research and policy work including the Workplace Justice Visa.
- As with any financial modelling, it is expected that any changes in the variables would result in changes to the SROI ratio. A sensitivity analysis has been conducted to explore which variable/s have the most significant impact on the ratio, including attribution, duration, and time period. For the scenarios tested, the SROI ratio remains above 1:1, indicating that the social value created is greater than the investment. Duration had the greatest impact on the SROI ratio of the variables tested.
- To calculate the present value, a process called discounting is used. This value is calculated after a discount rate of 2.5% is applied.
- For the detailed analysis, which includes a full list of assumptions and sources, along with detailed calculations, please contact MWC for the Impact Map.
- All values have been rounded.

Insights

MWC creates significant value for migrant workers and their communities. The SROI evaluation helps to understand how MWC creates this value and why its work is so important.

1

MWC plays a unique role in the services system.

MWC are the only organisation in Australia who provide casework support, community education, and carry out research and advocacy with a specific focus on migrant workers' rights. Other organisations like community legal centres and research institutes do some similar work, but no one else currently has the same expertise across all areas.

MWC's different areas of work reinforce one another. For example, community education sessions lead to greater take up of casework support. In interviews, staff identified an opportunity to work even more collaboratively in the future, by continuing to bridge the impact of MWC's casework support with their research and advocacy activities.

Staff and partner organisations reported significant demand for MWC's work, creating the opportunity for MWC to expand its reach to regional Victoria given appropriate resourcing. They also identified the opportunity for MWC to support other states and territories to set up similar centres.

"MWC are absolutely unique. There is no one else like them in Australia. It would be tremendous to have one in every capital city and regional centre." – Partner organisation

2

Language is critical.

MWC is committed to supporting migrant workers and communities in their preferred languages – over 50 languages throughout the evaluation period. This enables MWC to take its education activities to a much larger number of communities and to deliver high quality casework support. MWC have a team of staff that speak multiple, diverse languages, draw on the language support of the Bicultural Work Rights Ambassadors Program, and organise additional translators when needed.

“Because of the advice of MWC, the change in my situation was the difference between earth and sky.” – Worker supported by MWC



3

MWC's casework fills a significant gap in existing supports.

MWC's casework responds to significant unmet demand for free and accessible support to navigate underpayment, injury, bullying and termination issues among migrant workers. The value created throughout the evaluation period was significant, valued at \$4.45m total including \$1m in recovered entitlements such as wages and injury compensation.

In interviews, migrant workers explained a lack of options for support and difficulties navigating systems like WorkCover. MWC's free casework support in individuals' preferred languages was a critical enabler for these migrant workers to understand their rights and options. All migrant workers said that they would not have been able to get the same outcome without MWC because they had been unable to get the support that they needed anywhere else.

MWC paused their casework in FY23-24 to focus their resources on formally registering as a Community Legal Centre. Once registered, they will recommence providing casework support, combining legal expertise and their experience working with migrant communities.

"MWC are doing great things. They can educate and identify problems. However, they can't take legal action. If they had a lawyer, that would be great." – Partner organisation

4

MWC is committed to collective action.

MWC recognises that individual's experiences of exploitation at work reflect shared experiences among co-workers and migrant communities. They harness what they learn supporting individual migrant workers and communities to shape future casework, community education, and research and advocacy, to contribute to systemic change.

MWC also recognises the power of collaboration and teamwork. They work in strong partnership with others who bring complementary skills and relationships:

- Community services organisations have strong relationships with migrant workers and communities, expanding MWC's reach.
- Unions have connections to employees and advocate for workers' rights generally, expanding MWC's reach and strengthening MWC's advocacy.
- Academics and researchers have expertise in telling evidence-based stories, contributing to systemic change in attitudes, policy, and legislation.

MWC are deliberate about filling gaps in the services system and available supports, rather than duplicating what their partners already do. They are committed to continuing to work with their partners to empower migrant workers to understand their rights and enforce them in workplaces.

5

MWC's team bring lived experience and community connections to their work.

MWC's team (including Ambassadors) are members of the diverse migrant communities that they support. Many of them have directly experienced injustice in the workplace. Consultation also highlighted the expertise and professionalism of MWC's team. The lived experience and diversity of MWC's team was identified as being critical to providing high quality support to people with different experiences from diverse backgrounds and communities.

"MWC is a tremendously valuable, passionate, well connected, and articulate organisation." – Partner organisation

Appendix: Evaluation approach

Evaluation scope

The evaluation examines MWC's work from July 2021 to April 2024 (inclusive).

The analysis should be considered conservative as it does not overclaim and looks only at material outcomes, in line with the Principles of Social Value (Source: The Principles of Social Value, Social Value International, accessed September 2023).

Conservative judgements were used throughout the analysis for the attribution of outcomes to MWC, duration of outcomes, and an understanding of what would have happened anyway.

Critically, outcomes from MWC's research and policy work including the Workplace Justice Visa were not valued in the SROI due to complexities in attribution and value being realised after the evaluation period. These are discussed above.



Method

Social value is the value that people place on the changes that they experience in their lives. As an SROI evaluation, this evaluation's approach is guided by the Principles of Social Value, which provide the basic building blocks for anyone who wants to make decisions that take this wider definition of value into account.



Principles		Definition	Application in this SROI study
1	Involve stakeholders	Stakeholders should inform what gets measured and how this is measured and valued.	We conducted interviews with migrant workers, MWC staff, partner organisations, and funders. We worked in close partnership with MWC to understand their work and data.
2	Understand what changes	Articulate how change is created and evaluate this through evidence gathered, recognising positive and negative changes as well as those that are intended and unintended.	Analysis and consultation explored elements of MWC's approach that contribute to change (e.g., providing support in different languages). Questions in consultation were neutral (e.g., what changes did you experience?) rather than biased towards positive changes (e.g., how did your life improve?).
3	Value the things that matter	Use financial proxies so the value of the outcomes can be recognised.	We used financial proxies based on MWC data or already established in the literature to maximise the credibility of the evaluation.
4	Only include what is material	Determine what information and evidence must be included in the accounts to give a true and fair picture, such that stakeholders can draw reasonable conclusions about impact.	Analysis and consultation informed the quantities used in the SROI calculations and broader discussion of the outcomes in the report. We did not measure and value outcomes unless there was strong evidence to prove (and quantify) MWC's impact.
5	Do not overclaim	Organisations should only claim the value that they are responsible for creating.	Consultation explored 'what would have happened without the MWC' and the extent to which the MWC worked in partnership with other organisations to support outcomes. This informed how much value was attributed to the MWC.
6	Be transparent	Demonstrate the basis on which the analysis may be considered accurate and honest and show that it will be reported to and discussed with stakeholders.	The full set of assumptions and calculations is documented in the Impact Map (Excel). Key assumptions are included in this report.
7	Verify the results	Ensure appropriate independent verification of the analysis.	A Level 3 Advanced SROI and Social Value practioner provided guidance and support for the work.
8	Be responsive	Pursue optimum Social Value based decision making that is timely and supported by appropriate accounting and reporting.	The SROI analysis will be used to inform decisions about what support MWC provide and how. There is an opportunity for MWC to update the SROI in future years to build a view of their impact over time.

Data collection and consultation

MWC provided organisational data which was used to understand the support that they provided migrant workers and communities during the evaluation period. This included casework data, community education data, and survey data from individual migrant workers supported through casework, attendees at Know Your Rights sessions, partner organisations, and Ambassadors. The casework data was especially critical to understanding the change that MWC supports, as it recorded the number of cases supported, types of cases, and recovery amounts (where known by MWC). A key step in conducting the data analysis was linking the casework data across years, given updates in reporting to capture more detailed information about case types and outcomes in FY23-24.

SVA conducted interviews with the following stakeholders. Interviews with migrant workers were conducted in their preferred language, with an external translator present when needed.

Stakeholder group	Number of interviews
Migrant workers	8
Partner organisations	7
Funders	1
Ambassadors	3
MWC staff	6
Total	25

Insights from the interviews were invaluable to understanding the challenges that migrant workers and communities experience, change that MWC supports, and how the change is achieved. SVA would like to thank the individuals who contributed their time and expertise to the consultation process.

Applying the Principles of Social Value: worked example

This is a worked example of how the first five Principles of Social Value were applied to one outcome valued in the SROI.

1 Involve stakeholders

The stakeholder group for this example is **individuals supported through casework (excluding those who successfully recovered unpaid entitlements, whose outcomes are valued separately)**

2 Understand what changes

Example outcome: **Increased understanding of rights**

3 Value the things that matter

4 Include what is material

5 Do not overclaim

Quantity

How many people experienced a change?

Based on casework data, we counted 536 individuals in this stakeholder group.

Different levels of support were provided:

- 329 individuals (61%) received a relatively low level of support
- 114 individuals (21%) received a relatively moderate level of support
- 93 individuals (17%) received a relatively high level of support

Note that these numbers were estimated based on a sample of 75 cases.

Deadweight

How much of that change would have happened anyway?

It was determined that individual migrant workers supported through casework to increase understanding of their rights would not have experienced the outcome without MWC. This is due to MWC's unique expertise in migrant workers' rights and strong accessibility to migrant workers, contributed to by providing support in different languages.

Duration and Drop-off

How long did the impact of the change last?

Increased understanding of rights is valued for 5 years, as individuals supported through casework retain knowledge about their rights and support options after the period of casework support. It is assumed that the value of this knowledge drops off by 20% each year, reflecting the potential for changes to the individual's circumstances or legislation and decreasing influence of MWC.

329 individuals: 'low' support, up to 4 hours	x	\$850	x	0%	x	100%	5 Benefit period 20% Drop-off	=	\$939,000
114 individuals: 'moderate' support, 4-8 hours	x	\$1,840	x	0%	x	100%		=	\$710,000
93 individuals: 'high' support, >8 hours	x	\$3,040	x	0%	x	100%		=	\$949,000
Total									\$2,596,000

Financial Proxy

What is the value of this outcome to the stakeholder?

Value of courses to understand employment law and make workplace allegations.

- Introduction to employment law course: \$850
- Advanced employment law course: \$990
- Writing investigation reports and allegations course: \$1,200

The values of higher levels of support include the value(s) of lower levels of support, reflecting that understanding is built in stages.

Attribution

How much of this change was a result of MWC?

The value of increased understanding of rights is attributed completely to MWC. This was validated in interviews with migrant workers. Even in cases where partner or referral organisations play a complementary role, the value created by MWC stays the same as these organisations create additional value by offering different expertise to MWC.

Adjusted value

What's the value of the outcome?

The net value of the outcome after adjusting for quantity, financial proxy, attribution, deadweight, duration and drop-off.



Contact

For a copy of the Impact Map, which includes a full list of assumptions and sources, along with more detailed calculations, please contact MWC directly:

P: 03 7009 6710

E: mwc@migrantworkers.org.au





Social Ventures Australia

Brisbane | Darwin | Melbourne | Perth | Sydney | ABN 94 100 487 572 | AFSL 428 865

info@socialventures.org.au | socialventures.org.au | @Social_Ventures